

1 AlgoBOWL Resources for Spring 2026: `enclose.horse`

During the course of the AlgoBOWL project, you will be using the website <https://mines.algobowl.org/>. This document provides a concise overview of the various stages of the project, including the exact due dates and point distributions that are being used for the Spring 2026 competition. Please see this write-up for the specific NPC problem being featured this year: Canvas >>Files >>Projects >>Project 3: AlgoBOWL >>“AlgoBOWL Problem Description - Enclose Horse_SP26.pdf” Many thanks to our incredible TA, Nathan George, for designing this problem!

- The AlgoBOWL website is maintained by Jack Rosenthal, a Mines alum, one of the original co-creators of the AlgoBOWL project, and co-author with Professor Dinesh Mehta on an [ITiCSE paper](#) about the project.
- A more detailed explanation of all aspects of grading is available at <https://github.com/jackrosenthal/algobowl/blob/main/docs/rules.md>.
- Please use the [Teammate Check-In Form](#) at any time during the competition to share either **Positive Kudos** or **Challenging Issues** regarding your teammate(s). You may complete this form as many times as you'd like (or never).

2 Stages of AlgoBOWL

1. **Input Upload:** All teams design one input and upload it to the AlgoBOWL website. The input format will automatically be verified by the website software.

Due: Monday (4/06/26) at 10PM (**Teams without a valid input uploaded at this time will receive 0 out of 15 possible points for input upload.** However, they will receive an automatically-generated random input enabling them to continue participating in the rest of the competition.)

2. **Output Upload:** Inputs from each team become available for every team to download. Each team downloads the inputs from all other teams and produces an output for each input. The output must be uploaded to the AlgoBOWL website by the due date.

Note: No automatic verification is preformed. It is very important that you submit outputs which meet the specification; see the next stage for how verification is preformed.

Starts: Immediately after the end of the **Input Upload** stage.

Due: Thursday (4/09/26) at 10PM (teams without all outputs uploaded at this time will score poorly in the competition)

3. **Output Verification:** Each team downloads the outputs that all the other teams produced for their input. They use their verification software to mark the output as valid or invalid.

Starts: Immediately after the end of the **Output Upload** stage.

Due: Friday (4/10/26) at 10PM (teams without all outputs accepted or rejected at this time will score poorly in the competition)

But what happens if my output is rejected unfairly? Fear not! The next resolution stage allows you to protest errors made by other teams.

4. **Resolution (optional):** If the verifying team rejects your output, you will be sent an email with two options, which must be completed within 24 hours:

- You can **upload a new output**. The instructional team and TAs will verify the new output. This will come at the cost of one penalty point. If you submit a new output which is rejected, the rejection will be permanent and you will get no chance to reupload.
- You can **protest the verification**. The instructional team will verify your original output manually. If your output was correct, your output will be marked as accepted without penalty, and the verifying team will receive a reduction on the verification portion of their grade. If your output was incorrect, the rejection will be permanent and you will have no chance to reupload.

Starts: Within 24 hours after the end of the **Output Verification** stage.

Due: Saturday (4/11/26) at 10PM

5. **Open Verification (optional):** At this time, all outputs for all inputs will become available. Teams which question the accuracy of the verification of other teams may wish to download outputs. If they discover inaccuracies, they may submit a protest and the team which did not verify correctly will have the verification portion of their grade reduced.

Starts: 24 hours after the end of the **Output Verification** stage.

Due: Tuesday (4/14/26) at 10PM (end of competition)

6. **Group Evaluation (optional):** Each individual submits the effort contribution for each of their group members. This is used in the determination of the grade for the project; if it is not completed, we assume all teammates contributed equally.

Starts: Immediately after the end of the **Output Verification** stage.

Due: Tuesday (4/14/26) at 10PM (end of competition)

3 Grading Rubric

Points will be distributed according to the following distribution:

- **Valid Input Submitted:** 5 points
- **Input¹:** 10 points
- **Valid Outputs:** 50 points
- **Ranking:** 15 points
- **Verification:** 20 points

There are always many questions about the "Ranking" portion of the grade. The short explanation is that there will be two benchmarks provided by the TAs. If a team passes only the first benchmark, they earn 5 points. If a team passes the second benchmark, they earn 10 points. **This means that all teams are eligible to score *at least* 10 out of 15 of the ranking points.** The final 5 points are the only points that are impacted by actual ranking in competition against other teams. Consequently, this also implies (assuming everything else was done correctly) that **all** student teams could theoretically earn an A with 95% or higher on this project if they put in the effort to match the second TA benchmark.

The real world is competitive and performance matters. We do understand the concern about "competing for a grade." However, it is almost impossible for 5% of the score on a single project to meaningfully impact a final course grade (as this corresponds to only 0.005% of the overall final grade).

See the resource linked [here](#) for more complete details about grading. (This is the same document that is linked at the beginning of this document.)

¹The input grade will be determined based on the maximum of the input difficulty score and the input creation description

4 Diagram of the Stages

Please note that the resolution stage is omitted from this diagram.

